

How a Simple Request Becomes an Administrative Problem

Bureaucratic Drift, Procedural Burden, and Reality Drift

Reality Drift Framework — Taxonomy Note #2

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The Basic Pattern

A person begins with a simple need.

The institution cannot act on the need directly.

It must first convert the need into a category, form, case, ticket, or approved workflow.

The core sequence is:

human need → administrative category → procedural routing → compliance burden →
bureaucratic drift

What Is Bureaucratic Drift?

Bureaucratic Drift occurs when administrative procedures gradually become more important than the outcomes they were created to support.

The system still processes requests.

Forms are completed.

Cases are routed.

Rules are followed.

But the person's original need becomes increasingly distant from the process.

The Request Journey

The Need

A person needs help, permission, access, correction, or resolution.

The need is immediate and understandable.

The Category

The institution translates the need into an official classification.

Anything that does not fit the available categories becomes harder to recognize.

The Procedure

The person must follow a required sequence of forms, approvals, evidence, and handoffs.

The process becomes the only accepted path to action.

The Burden

The person must learn the system's language, maintain the account, track the status, repeat information, and prove eligibility.

The original need now carries an administrative shadow.

The Outcome

The process may be completed successfully.

The need may remain unresolved.

Why the Process Expands

Procedures are added to reduce risk, improve consistency, create accountability, and prevent mistakes.

Each addition is usually reasonable.

Over time, safeguards accumulate.

Exceptions produce new rules.

New rules create new documentation.

The system becomes easier to audit and harder to navigate.

Bureaucratic Drift and Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, Bureaucratic Drift begins when the representation of the need becomes more authoritative than the need itself.

The category outranks the circumstance.

The form outranks the explanation.

The completed process outranks the actual result.

The institution remains operational because the workflow continues.

Bureaucratic Drift occurs when procedural correctness becomes a substitute for practical resolution.

The Core Principle

Bureaucracy does not usually fail by refusing to act.

It fails by acting on the administrative representation instead of the reality behind it.

The request enters as a human need.

It exits as a completed case.

Those are not always the same thing.

The process can succeed while the person remains unhelped.

Keywords: bureaucratic drift, administrative burden, procedural burden, why simple requests become complicated, digital bureaucracy, forms and workflows, institutional friction, compliance burden, proceduralization, administrative legibility, Reality Drift, A. Jacobs